

The 6:15

MONDAY · SEPTEMBER 28, 2026

NO. 20

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Tue 9/29	Yankees host Red Sox, ALWC Series Gm 1, Yankee Stadium (start time unconfirmed: 6:08p vs. 8:00p ET across trackers)
Wed 9/30, 8:30a	August PCE price index (BEA) — first inflation print since the Sept. 16 hike; core seen +0.5% m/m (one tracker, not cross-verified)
Thu 10/1	Nike FQ1 2027 earnings after close; consensus \$0.44 EPS/\$11.32B rev (TipRanks/Benzinga, single-sourced)
Fri 10/2, 7:00p	Northwestern hosts Penn State, Ryan Field
Mon 10/5	Knicks preseason opens at Philadelphia (5-game slate through Oct. 15, NBA-confirmed)

Standing overhang: FOMC next meets Oct. 27-28, now priced by CME FedWatch/Polymarket at 64%-73% odds of a second 2026 hike, up from the low-30s before September's decision. Next government funding deadline Dec. 11 (the Sept. 2 stopgap, formally the Continuing Appropriations and Extensions Act, 2027, cleared the House 370-48 and Senate 90-6 — a deliberate bipartisan push to keep any shutdown fight away from the midterm ballot box). OPEC+'s October JMMC date still unconfirmed [continuity]. SpaceX's Starship Flight 14 — the vehicle's first orbital attempt and first flight with an operational payload (26 Starlink V3 satellites, each adding roughly 1 Tbps of constellation capacity) — has a launch window this morning, 8:15a-9:30a ET; no liftoff confirmed as of this writing [NEW]. No new frontier AI-model releases confirmed overnight [continuity — see Technology].

METRICS · ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI	Brent \$106.89-\$107.82 (+2.5% to +3.4%, range across trackers, ~5a-9a ET); WTI \$94.10-\$95.05 (+1.8% to +2.3%); spread ~\$12-13
10Y / 30Y / 2Y	10Y 5.21% (+2bp); 30Y 5.52% (+2bp), both still in the 2007-high territory flagged in issue No. 19; 2Y not confirmed as of press time (last: 4.81%, Fri 9/25 close)
DXY	101.11 (+0.08%), holding near Friday's two-month high — up 1.70% over the past month and 3.28% over 12

months

S&P / Nasdaq futures	S&P 500 futures +0.47%, Nasdaq 100 futures +0.40%, Dow futures +0.86% (premarket); cash open not yet confirmed
VIX	Not confirmed as of press time (last: 14.87, Fri 9/25 close)
Gold	\$4,146.98-\$4,156.76 (-2.99%), a seven-week low — real-yield and dollar strength (above) outweighing the safe-haven bid from Hormuz, the inverse of the usual crisis playbook
Asia (Mon close)	Nikkei 66,333.53 (-0.1%); Hang Seng 24,684.09 (+0.7%); ASX 200 8,688.60 (+0.3%); Kospi 6,916.30 (-2.3%); Shanghai Composite 3,820.82 (-1.7%)
Europe	Mid-session, not confirmed as of press time
Retail gas	AAA national average \$4.4768/gal (as of 9/28), -\$0.0018 w/w — still near the calendar-date record flagged Saturday

Oil's overnight bid is the Iran-rejection headline (see Lead); no single Brent/WTI settle reconciles across sources this morning — treat the complex as directional, not a printed number.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Transits	1 recorded Sept. 20 vs. 85/day pre-crisis baseline (IMF PortWatch via straits.live, as of 4:55a ET) — a 98.8% reduction; the tracker's own data runs days behind real time
Vessels holding	177 AIS-visible vessels in the Gulf watch box as of 4:55a ET, down from 233 at 10:49p ET Sunday (unexplained same-day swing — treat as tracker noise, not confirmed de-escalation) ; comparable recent reads on this same counter have run 219, 243 and 214, so the range itself has been noisy for weeks, not just today
War-risk premia	7.5%-10% of hull value fleet-wide (Howden Re/Marsh/S&P Global) — roughly \$3M-\$10M per transit on a \$100M tanker vs. ~\$250K pre-conflict; an industry-range figure, not quantified in today's straits.live brief
Crisis events	95 indexed events, trailing 24h (straits.live's proprietary Hormuz Index — single-sourced)

Methodology: transit counts (PortWatch, lagged), stranded-vessel counts (AIS analysis, same-day volatility) and war-risk premia (insurance-market reporting, periodic) measure different things over different windows and vendors; never averaged or differenced here. Two new disclosed incidents this run — 8 US Marines injured Sept. 14 in a previously undisclosed Iranian missile strike, and a disputed second REMUS 600 drone-seizure claim — are detailed in Iran & Hormuz.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Host Red Sox, ALWC Series Gm 1, Tue 9/29 at Yankee Stadium; no other moves
Knicks	Signed rookie wing Tyler Nickel to a two-way deal Sun 9/27; full 5-game preseason schedule now NBA-confirmed (Oct. 5 at Philadelphia, Oct. 8 vs. Wizards, Oct. 12 vs. Timberwolves, Oct. 13 at Toronto, Oct. 15 vs. Raptors)
Northwestern	No reported moves in the last 24 hours

LEAD

IRAN / HORMUZ

Iran's foreign minister rules out re-engaging with Trump "even if it comes to a doomsday war"; Trump calls Tehran's offer overplayed but still expects talks this week

Saturday's rejection (carried in issue No. 19) hardened overnight. On NBC's "Meet the Press," Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Iran has "no reason to come back to diplomacy and engage with this administration once again," citing repeated US strikes through Trump's second term, and warned: "We stand firm in the face of any aggression against us, even if it comes to a doomsday war." That is a materially new line from Tehran's foreign minister, not a restatement. He also dismissed Trump's public rejection as inconsistent with what has actually reached Iran through mediators: "The US president has made some good remarks as well as many contradictory ones, which unfortunately we hear from him frequently." Formally, little has

changed since Sunday — Araghchi again said Qatar and Pakistan have conveyed nothing from Washington — but the tone has: Saturday's story was a stalled channel; today's is a foreign minister disclaiming any obligation to use it at all.

Trump's own position is harder to pin down than Araghchi's. In an Axios interview Sunday, he said the terms Iran is now offering are ones Washington "might have agreed to about a year ago," and that Tehran had "overplayed its hand" — dismissive language pointed at the same seven-day roadmap this desk covered Saturday. In the same interview, he said he expects negotiations to resume this week regardless. Those two statements are not obviously reconcilable, and neither outlet reports which reflects an operative US position. That ambiguity is arguably now the larger variable than Iran's posture: markets have one clear, hardening data point out of Tehran and two contradictory ones out of Washington.

The scale of the underlying conflict came into sharper relief this morning with a disclosure that wasn't part of Saturday's or Sunday's coverage. The Pentagon has confirmed that eight US Marines were injured — smoke inhalation and possible concussion symptoms, all returned to duty — when an Iranian anti-ship missile struck a vessel they were operating from in the Strait on Sept. 14, an incident not disclosed for two weeks. Separately, Iran's IRGC says it seized a second US REMUS 600 underwater surveillance drone on Sept. 27 via "a coordinated, complex operation involving intelligence oversight and electronic warfare"; US Central Command denies it, consistent with its denial of a similar Iranian claim on Sept. 8 that the Pentagon said actually involved a malfunctioning, non-sensitive older drone. Both are single-source claims running against single-source denials, unresolved as of this writing.

None of this shows up yet in this issue's Hormuz counters — transit volume and stranded-vessel counts move on days-long lags and show no fresh signal either way (Board). What did move overnight is price: Brent jumped as much as 3.4% to a \$106.89-\$107.82 range and WTI to \$94-95, both erasing Friday's late-week pullback, on the rejection headline alone. That is the mechanism worth sitting with — the market is pricing Araghchi's words, not any change in physical flows or strike activity, because at this stage of the crisis rhetoric is the leading indicator and hardware follows with a lag. Oman's standing mediation offer, reiterated over the weekend and carried in issue No. 19, has drawn no new comment from either side this morning; it remains the one channel neither Washington nor Tehran has explicitly closed, even as both talk past it.

The second-order read: a Fed that hiked Sept. 16 and is now priced by CME FedWatch and Polymarket at 64%-73% odds of hiking again Oct. 27-28 — up from the low-30s before the September decision, on hawkish commentary from Governor Barr rather than a new data print — is watching an oil complex re-accelerate into Wednesday's PCE release at the exact moment the diplomatic off-ramp that might have relieved that pressure is being disclaimed by name by Iran's own foreign minister. A hiking central bank, a record-adjacent retail gas price, and a war whose rhetorical temperature rose today on both the Iranian-rhetoric and disclosed-casualty fronts is a less forgiving setup than the "diplomacy stalled but not dead" framing this desk carried through the weekend. Nothing here is a forecast of Wednesday's print or of Tehran's next move; it's a note that the range of plausible outcomes widened overnight in the direction markets like least — persistent, not resolving, and now

with a clearer disclosed cost in American casualties than this desk had before this morning.

Equities are, for now, shrugging: S&P 500 and Nasdaq 100 futures are both higher in premarket trading alongside the oil and yield moves, not against them, which reads less like conviction that the Iran story is contained and more like a market that spent last week pricing a war economy and isn't re-pricing it sharply on an incremental rhetorical escalation. Cash-open behavior once the PCE-week session actually gets underway will say more than the futures print does.

POLITICS

Monday brought the first concrete follow-through on Friday's Trump-Xi summit: China confirmed the two-month US-China trade truce extension runs to Jan. 10, which Beijing says creates "a relatively stable and predictable policy environment" for continued talks. Terms disclosed since Friday's "pomp over substance" wrap (issue No. 19) include tariff cuts on \$30B of goods, a bilateral AI-incident communication channel with a follow-up dialogue promised by late November, and a Chinese commitment to review US-capital financial institutions for branch licenses. Analysts quoted across outlets still flag the two-month window itself — short relative to the fanfare of the visit — as evidence the detente's durability remains unresolved rather than settled by the summit. None of this touches the Iran file: Taiwan, Ukraine and the Iran war were all reportedly raised in the Trump-Xi discussions, but produced no deliverable, and rare-earth-export and technology-control disputes remain separately unresolved. The AI-incident channel is the one concrete institutional output of the summit beyond trade — a standing line of

communication plus a named follow-up date (end of November) — and is worth tracking against this issue's Technology item on the pace of frontier-model releases from US labs.

ECONOMICS

The week's single load-bearing data point is Wednesday's 8:30a ET August PCE release — the first inflation read since the Sept. 16 hike and the last one before the Oct. 27-28 FOMC meeting. One forecaster tracker puts consensus core PCE at +0.5% m/m (vs. July's +0.1%) and annual headline/core near 6.6%/4.7%; neither figure is cross-verified against a second source this run, so treat both as directional rather than settled consensus. Hike odds for October have already moved on commentary alone: CME FedWatch and Polymarket both show 64%-73% probability of a second 2026 hike, up from roughly 30% before September's meeting, following hawkish remarks last week from Fed Governor Michael Barr flagging accelerating price pressure. A hot PCE print Wednesday would be the data point that turns "priced" into "expected" rather than the commentary that has driven the repricing so far. The Dec. 11 funding deadline (Calendar, Board) sits far enough out that it isn't yet a market factor, but it's the next fiscal cliff this desk is tracking once PCE and the FOMC meeting clear.

BUSINESS

Nike reports fiscal Q1 2027 after Thursday's close; consensus (TipRanks/Benzinga, single-sourced this run) is \$0.44 EPS on \$11.32B revenue, implying an 11% EPS decline and 3% revenue decline year-over-year — a low bar management cleared by 54% last quarter, per the same trackers. Earnings Whispers' calendar shows 31

companies reporting today alone, thinning to 9 Tuesday, 11 Wednesday, 7 Thursday and 2 Friday, with nothing yet confirmed as a premarket mover. Q3 earnings season proper doesn't begin in earnest until the second full week of October, per multiple trackers, so this week's prints — Nike included — are early and lower-cap relative to what follows; no additional single-name mover was confirmed by this run's research beyond the Nike date and its Thursday-after-close timing. Nike's own guidance commentary, when it lands, will be read partly through a tariff lens given the still-unresolved US-China trade terms above and the company's China-manufacturing exposure — a connection this desk will revisit once the print is in hand rather than pre-judging it here.

TECHNOLOGY

September's frontier-model wave is now a continuity item rather than daily news: Anthropic, OpenAI, Google and Meta each shipped new models in the month's first days (Claude Fable 5.1/Mythos 5.1, GPT-6 Astra's broad release, Gemini 3.8 Flash, Muse Spark 1.3), and trackers count 20-plus further releases in a "late-September wave," with one tracker citing a 119x spread in per-token pricing across the released models and a new \$0.10-per-million-token price floor. No single-vendor headline broke overnight, so this desk isn't re-itemizing each release going forward — only genuine step-changes will get flagged [NEW] from here. The one hard date this morning: SpaceX's Starship Flight 14, the vehicle's first orbital attempt and first flight carrying an operational payload (26 Starlink V3 satellites), has a launch window at 8:15a-9:30a ET; ship and booster are planned for splashdown rather than catch on this flight, and no liftoff is confirmed as of this writing.

GEOPOLITICS

The Houthi-Saudi front escalated in frequency, not just intensity: Saturday's intercepted attack (two ballistic missiles toward Khamis Mushait, two drones toward Riyadh) came just two days after the coalition downed six ballistic missiles aimed at Yanbu and Taif on Sept. 24 — two attacks in four days, a faster cadence than this desk had been tracking. The GCC secretary-general called the escalation "a serious violation of Saudi Arabia's sovereignty and a direct threat to civilian safety and regional stability." The notable structural response: Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey have signed a Makkah Joint Defense Agreement treating an armed attack on any one signatory as an attack on all — a mutual-defense pact reported here for the first time this run, distinct from and additional to the existing US security relationship with Riyadh. The Houthis have run a declared naval blockade against Saudi Arabia since July, separate from and not confirmed to be coordinated with Iran's Strait of Hormuz closure, though both feed the same regional war-risk backdrop priced into this issue's Board.

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the Lead's rejection story, the physical counters (Board) show no confirmed change: transit counts are still lagging (last dated Sept. 20) and the vessel-holding count swung from 233 to 177 within a single day on straits.live's own numbers — a swing the tracker doesn't explain, so treat it as noise in the count rather than a signal of easing. War-risk premia are reported this run only as an industry-wide range (7.5%-10% of hull value) rather than a daily print, because today's straits.live brief didn't quantify them — a

methodology gap, not a resolved figure; for scale, that range implies roughly \$3M-\$10M in added insurance cost on a single \$100M-hull tanker transit, against about \$250,000 pre-conflict. The two new disclosed incidents — the Sept. 14 Marine casualties, revealed only today, and the disputed second REMUS 600 seizure claim, which follows an already-denied Sept. 8 claim involving what the Pentagon says was a malfunctioning, non-sensitive older drone — both suggest a more active, less fully disclosed shadow war than this desk's running Hormuz counters currently capture.

SPORTS

Yankees	No game since Fri 9/25 loss to Baltimore (89-65, still unreconciled vs. this outlet's own 91-67 tally — see issue No. 19); host Red Sox in ALWC Gm 1 Tue 9/29.
Knicks	No game; signed two-way rookie Tyler Nickel Sun 9/27 (53-29 last season, defending champions); preseason opens Oct. 5 at Philadelphia.
Northwestern	No game since Fri 9/25 loss at Indiana, 29-23 (2-1); hosts Penn State Fri 10/2, 7:00p, Ryan Field.

Continuity. Dropped or carried without repeating from issue No. 19: European closes (not yet closed as of this writing), VIX and 2Y intraday levels (not confirmed; Friday's closes carried instead), OPEC+'s exact October JMMC date (still unconfirmed), and the Ukraine/Sumy and CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House press-access threads (not re-searched this run). Watch for next issue: Wednesday's PCE print and its effect on Oct. 27-28 hike odds; whether the Yankees-Red Sox ALWC Gm 1 start time resolves; Starship Flight 14's outcome; and whether Araghchi's "doomsday war" language is echoed or walked back by Tehran through the week.

Unverified figures flagged this issue: the exact Brent/WTI settle (range given, not reconciled), 2Y and VIX levels (not confirmed, prior close carried), the August PCE consensus figures (single-tracker, not cross-verified), Nike's earnings consensus (single-sourced), the Yankees ALWC Gm 1 start time (two conflicting times reported), and the straits.live vessel-holding count's 233-to-177 same-day swing (unexplained by the source). Nothing above was estimated or filled from memory.